

Guitar Head

An all-valve guitar amp with spring reverb and a 2×12 or 4×12 cabinet.



Overview

Guitar Head is an all-valve guitar amplifier in the spirit of the classic 50-watt heads. The preamp has a clean channel with one valve, from sparkly to edge-of-breakup, and a DRIVE channel that cascades a second valve for more gain. Then come a tone stack, a spring reverb tank, and a push-pull power stage that sags and crunches as you drive it.

A cabinet stage follows, with a 2×12 open-back or 4×12 closed-back cabinet and a microphone that you can move from on axis to off axis. Turn the cabinet off to use the amp as a line-out head into your own cabinet plugin or impulse response.

The amp runs in true stereo at twice the sample rate for cleaner distortion: left and right each go through their own identical amp, preamp to cabinet, with all the controls linked and one shared power supply. The two spring tanks differ slightly, so the reverb opens out into stereo; for a mono guitar, switch MONO IN on. A built-in noise gate and tuner complete the head.

Reach for it for

- Clean and edge-of-breakup guitar tones
- Classic rock crunch and lead tones (DRIVE, MASTER)
- Re-amping DI guitar recordings

- Spring reverb on guitars
- A head into your own cabinet plugin (CAB OFF)

Controls

The amp

GAIN	The preamp gain, 0 to 10 (5 by default). On the clean channel it goes from sparkly to edge-of-breakup; with DRIVE on it goes much further.
BRIGHT	A treble lift in front of the gain. It is strongest at low GAIN settings and fades as you turn GAIN up, like the bright switch on a real amp.
DRIVE	Off: the clean channel (one valve). On: a second cascaded valve for more gain and sustain, with a tighter low end.
BASS / MIDDLE / TREBLE	The tone stack, 0 to 10 each; 5 is flat.
PRESENCE	The top end after the power stage, 0 to 10 (5 by default).
REVERB	The level of the spring reverb, 0 to 10 (2 by default). The spring tank sits between the preamp and the power stage.
MASTER	How hard the power stage is driven, 0 to 10 (4 by default): first headroom, then sag and crunch as you turn it up.

The lower strip

GATE	A noise gate in front of the amp, from OFF (fully down) to -20 dB. Raise it until the hiss and hum between notes disappear.
TUNER	Switches the tuner on. While it is on, the output is muted and the display shows the note and how far off it is; the note turns green when you are in tune. With no note it reads PLAY A NOTE.

MONO IN	Lit: the two inputs are summed and the same signal feeds both sides of the amp, as with one guitar into one head; the stereo spring reverb still gives width. Off (the default): stereo sources such as keyboards stay stereo.
CAB	The cabinet: OFF (line out, no cabinet), 2×12 OPEN (open back, the default) or 4×12 (closed back, more low end).
MIC	The microphone position, 0 (on axis, brighter) to 10 (off axis, darker and smoother); 3 by default.
OUTPUT	Output level, -24 to +12 dB.
LEVEL	A row of ten LEDs showing the output peak level, from -30 dB up to just under 0 dBFS.

The header

Pilot lamp	Shows the amp is on; it takes the theme's accent colour.
Theme picker	Changes the colour of the control panel, pinstripe and lamp.
HW	Switches between the hardware faceplate and the flat look.
S / M / L	Panel size: small, medium or large.
?	Opens a pop-up with the design credit, the GFX website address and the address of this manual. Click anywhere to close it.

Tips

- For edge-of-breakup, keep DRIVE off, set GAIN around 6 - 8 and let MASTER add the crunch as you dig in.
- BRIGHT is most useful at low GAIN settings, where it adds sparkle to clean tones; at high gain it does little.
- Set CAB to OFF when you want to use your own cabinet plugin or impulse response after the head.

- Move MIC towards 10 to smooth out a harsh, fizzy top end before reaching for TREBLE.
- Use TUNER between takes; remember it mutes the output while it is on.

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